



Grade 9 FAST ELA Reading

2025 Released Test Items

A White Heron

by Sarah Orne Jewett

In this excerpt of a short story set in rural Maine in the late 1800s, a young girl named Sylvia meets a young man studying birds. He is trying to find a rare bird, the white heron. This scene starts with the young man speaking to Mrs. Tilley, Sylvia's grandmother.

- 1 "I caught a glimpse of a white heron a few miles from here on Saturday, and I have followed it in this direction. They have never been found in this district at all. The little white heron, it is," and he turned again to look at Sylvia with the hope of discovering that the rare bird was one of her acquaintances.
- 2 But Sylvia was watching a hop-toad in the narrow footpath.
- 3 "You would know the heron if you saw it," the stranger continued eagerly. "A queer tall white bird with soft feathers and long thin legs. And it would have a nest perhaps in the top of a high tree, made of sticks, something like a hawk's nest."
- 4 Sylvia's heart gave a wild beat; she knew that strange white bird, and had once stolen softly near where it stood in some bright green swamp grass, away over at the other side of the woods. There was an open place where the sunshine always seemed strangely yellow and hot, where tall, nodding rushes grew, and her grandmother had warned her that she might sink in the soft black mud underneath Not far beyond were the salt marshes just this side the sea itself, which Sylvia wondered and dreamed much about, but never had seen, whose great voice could sometimes be heard above the noise of the woods on stormy nights.
- 5 "I can't think of anything I should like so much as to find that heron's nest," the handsome stranger was saying. "I would give ten dollars to anybody who could show it to me," he added desperately, "and I mean to spend my whole vacation hunting for it if need be. Perhaps it was only migrating, or had been chased out of its own region by some bird of prey."
- 6 Mrs. Tilley gave amazed attention to all this, but Sylvia still watched the toad, not divining, as she might have done at some calmer time, that the creature wished to get to its hole under the door-step, and was much hindered by the unusual spectators at that hour of the evening. No amount of thought, that night, could decide how many wished-for treasures the ten dollars, so lightly spoken of, would buy.

- 7 The next day the young sportsman hovered about the woods, and Sylvia kept him company, having lost her first fear of the friendly lad, who proved to be most kind and sympathetic. He told her many things about the birds and what they knew and where they lived and what they did with themselves. And he gave her a jack-knife, which she thought as great a treasure as if she were a desert-islander. All day long he did not once make her troubled or afraid except when he brought down some unsuspecting singing creature from its bough. . . . But as the day waned, Sylvia still watched the young man with loving admiration. She had never seen anybody so charming and delightful They stopped to listen to a bird's song; they pressed forward again eagerly, parting the branches—speaking to each other rarely and in whispers; the young man going first and Sylvia following, fascinated, a few steps behind, with her gray eyes dark with excitement.
- 8 She grieved because the longed-for white heron was elusive, but she did not lead the guest, she only followed, and there was no such thing as speaking first. The sound of her own unquestioned voice would have terrified her—it was hard enough to answer yes or no when there was need of that. At last evening began to fall, and they drove the cow home together, and Sylvia smiled with pleasure when they came to the place where she heard the whistle and was afraid only the night before.
- 9 Half a mile from home, at the farther edge of the woods, where the land was highest, a great pine-tree stood, the last of its generation. Whether it was left for a boundary mark, or for what reason, no one could say; the woodchoppers who had felled its mates were dead and gone long ago, and a whole forest of sturdy trees, pines and oaks and maples, had grown again. But the stately head of this old pine towered above them all and made a landmark for sea and shore miles and miles away. Sylvia knew it well. She had always believed that whoever climbed to the top of it could see the ocean; and the little girl had often laid her hand on the great rough trunk and looked up wistfully at those dark boughs that the wind always stirred, no matter how hot and still the air might be below. Now she thought of the tree with a new excitement, for why, if one climbed it at break of day could not one see all the world, and easily discover from whence the white heron flew, and mark the place, and find the hidden nest?
- 10 What a spirit of adventure, what wild ambition! What fancied triumph and delight and glory for the later morning when she could make known the secret! It was almost too real and too great for the childish heart to bear.

- 11 All night the door of the little house stood open and the whippoorwills came and sang upon the very step. The young sportsman and his old hostess were sound asleep, but Sylvia's great design kept her broad awake and watching. She forgot to think of sleep. The short summer night seemed as long as the winter darkness, and at last when the whippoorwills ceased, and she was afraid the morning would after all come too soon, she stole out of the house and followed the pasture path through the woods, hastening toward the open ground beyond, listening with a sense of comfort and companionship to the drowsy twitter of a half-awakened bird, whose perch she had jarred in passing. Alas, if the great wave of human interest which flooded for the first time this dull little life should sweep away the satisfactions of an existence heart to heart with nature and the dumb life of the forest!

Excerpt from "A White Heron" by Sarah Orne Jewett. In the public domain.

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1. How do the descriptions of the heron in paragraphs 1–3 contribute to the plot of the passage?
- Ⓐ They indicate why the heron is unique.
 - Ⓑ They foreshadow how the heron will be found.
 - Ⓒ They introduce different opinions on the heron.
 - Ⓓ They suggest that many people care about the heron.

2. Read this sentence from the passage.

“Not far beyond were the salt marshes just this side the sea itself, which Sylvia wondered and dreamed much about, but never had seen, whose great voice could sometimes be heard above the noise of the woods on stormy nights.” (paragraph 4)

How does the personification of the sea affect the mood of the passage?

- Ⓐ The magnificence of the sound creates an intriguing mood.
- Ⓑ The treacherousness of the storms creates an uneasy mood.
- Ⓒ The contrast between dreams and reality creates a hopeful mood.
- Ⓓ The distance between the woods and the water creates a lonely mood.

3. How does paragraph 4 develop irony?

- Ⓐ by revealing that Sylvia knows more about the bird than she says aloud
- Ⓑ by revealing that the terrain is more varied than an outsider might assume
- Ⓒ by revealing that the area is more dangerous than it might initially appear to be
- Ⓓ by revealing that Sylvia is more curious about the young man than she pretends to be

4. Read these sentences from the passage.

“But as the day waned, Sylvia still watched the young man with loving admiration. She had never seen anybody so charming and delightful”
(paragraph 7)

How does the exaggeration “She had never seen anybody so charming and delightful” contribute to the sense of cheerfulness in the paragraph?

- Ⓐ It implies that Sylvia likes to make friends.
- Ⓑ It reflects the enthusiasm that Sylvia feels.
- Ⓒ It implies that the young man knows Sylvia well.
- Ⓓ It reflects the fanciful nature of what Sylvia wants.

- 5.** Read this sentence from the passage.

“Now she thought of the tree with a new excitement, for why, if one climbed it at break of day could not one see all the world, and easily discover from whence the white heron flew, and mark the place, and find the hidden nest?” (paragraph 9)

How does this rhetorical question contribute to the passage?

- Ⓐ It reveals Sylvia’s desire to avoid returning home.
- Ⓑ It highlights Sylvia’s desire to learn more about local plant life.
- Ⓒ It reveals Sylvia’s confidence in being able to find the white heron.
- Ⓓ It highlights Sylvia’s frustration at not locating the white heron yet.

6. Read this sentence.

“The short summer night seemed as long as the winter darkness, and at last when the whippoorwills ceased, and she was afraid the morning would after all come too soon, she stole out of the house and followed the pasture path through the woods, hastening toward the open ground beyond, listening with a sense of comfort and companionship to the drowsy twitter of a half-awakened bird, whose perch she had jarred in passing.” (paragraph 11)

What is the meaning of jarred as it is used in the sentence?

- Ⓐ bumped
- Ⓑ opened
- Ⓒ ruined
- Ⓓ stored

7. Read this paragraph.

10 What a spirit of adventure, what wild ambition! What fancied triumph and delight and glory for the later morning when she could make known the secret! It was almost too real and too great for the childish heart to bear.

How does this paragraph contribute to the universal theme about the joys of childhood in the passage?

- Ⓐ by highlighting how some emotions can feel overwhelming
- Ⓑ by implying that searching for glory is an immature ambition
- Ⓒ by highlighting how the future always seems more promising than the present
- Ⓓ by implying that secrets can undermine the strength of important relationships

- 8.** This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

Part A

Which universal theme does the passage develop?

- Ⓐ People can quickly form a bond over shared goals.
- Ⓑ People should share their knowledge with each other.
- Ⓒ People can pass on their wisdom to future generations.
- Ⓓ People should work together to protect the environment.

Part B

Which relationship in the passage develops the universal theme in Part A?

- Ⓐ Sylvia's respect for the bird
- Ⓑ Sylvia's interest in the young man
- Ⓒ Sylvia's devotion to her grandmother
- Ⓓ Sylvia's concern for the environment

Passage 1: Small Talk Is Overrated

1 “Hi! How are you?”

2 “Good. How about you?”

3 “Good. How about this weather?”

4 “I know, it’s so gorgeous outside, but tomorrow it’s supposed to rain.”

5 So it begins—the conversation that I’ve had one thousand times. This kind of inane small talk puts my brain to sleep. Even though small talk is a ritual that is supposed to make talking to strangers and acquaintances easier, it really hinders my ability to connect with other people. It becomes consuming, the way a simple question turns into a five-minute conversation about nothing. Small talk has infiltrated every part of my life, too. I found myself asking my great-uncle how work was at the last family gathering. He’s been retired for seven years, but the question popped up like a reflex.

6 Why is small talk so terrible? For me, the problem is that it feels fake and repetitive. We ask questions where the answer is either obvious or trivial, and the answers are practically scripted. The anthropological term for these kinds of conversations is a “phatic expression.” Phatic expressions are meant to create or maintain social relationships, not convey information. So small talk is meaningful *because* it’s meaningless? That feels backwards. Why not just skip the formalities and have a genuine conversation instead?

7 I don’t think I’m alone in wanting more interesting conversations. There are hundreds of thousands of articles online about how to get better at small talk, which suggests that many people are looking for alternatives. Most social etiquette “experts” will recommend some combination of the following:

- Asking your conversation partner questions because people love talking about themselves
- Being an active listener who expresses interest in what your conversation partner says
- Elaborating on your answers so that your conversation partner has more information to respond to

8 Basically, the experts are recommending that you break the script and get the other person to improvise. This is the secret that these experts don’t want to admit: good conversationalists aren’t having better small talk; they’re turning small talk into meaningful conversations. But to have that kind of conversation, both people need to be willing participants, and not every stranger or acquaintance wants to have a heart-to-heart or an intellectual debate.

- 9 There is an alternate solution: companionable silence. So often, we describe silence as “uncomfortable” or “awkward,” but we should embrace these quiet moments instead. Pressure to socially conform has been shown to contribute to stress and anxiety. If we could accept silence as natural, a lot of talking just for the sake of it could be avoided. Sometimes, there just isn’t anything that needs to be said.

“Small Talk Is Overrated” written for educational purposes.

Passage 2: Do People Need Small Talk to Be Happy?

by Stephanie Hayes

- 10 Psychologists have long said that connecting with others is central to well-being, but just how much conversation we require is under investigation. In one study, researchers eavesdropped on undergraduates for four days, then cataloged each overheard conversation as either “small talk” (“What do you have there? Popcorn? Yummy!”) or “substantive” (“So did they get divorced soon after?”). They found that the second type correlated with happiness—the happiest students had roughly twice as many substantive talks as the unhappiest ones. Small talk, meanwhile, made up only 10 percent of their conversation, versus almost 30 percent of conversation among the least content students.
- 11 But don’t write off chitchat just yet. Scientists believe that small talk (which linguists describe as a form of “phatic communication”) could promote bonding. Late last year, Princeton researchers reported that ring-tailed lemurs reserve their call-and-response conversations, akin to human chitchat, for the animals they groom the most—suggesting that small talk maintains closeness with loved ones, and isn’t merely the stuff of awkward exchanges with strangers.
- 12 Still, bantering with strangers could brighten your morning. In a series of experiments, psychologists gave Chicago commuters varying directions about whether to talk with fellow train passengers—something they typically avoided. Those told to chat with others reported a more pleasant journey than those told to “enjoy your solitude” or to do whatever they normally would. None of the chatters reported being rebuffed. And the results held for introverts and extroverts alike—which makes sense, since acting extroverted has a positive effect on introverts.
- 13 Small talk can also help us feel connected to our surroundings. People who smiled at, made eye contact with, and briefly spoke with

their Starbucks baristas reported a greater sense of belonging than those who rushed through the transaction. Similarly, one not yet published paper found that when volunteers broke the silence of the Tate Modern¹ to chat with gallerygoers, the visitors felt happier and more connected to the exhibit than those who were not approached.

14 Of course, some of us are better than others at turning small talk into something bigger. In one study, people who were rated “less curious” by researchers had trouble getting a conversation rolling on their own, and had greater luck building closeness with others when they were supplied with questions that encouraged personal disclosure (“When did you last cry in front of someone?”). But people who were deemed “curious” needed no help transforming conversations about mundane things like favorite holidays into intimate exchanges. A “curious mind-set,” the authors concluded, can lead to “positive social interactions.”

15 So go ahead, pry. Chitchat needn’t be idle. And nosiness isn’t all bad.

¹ Tate Modern: an art museum in London, England

Excerpt from “Do People Need Small Talk to Be Happy?” by Stephanie Hayes, from *The Atlantic*.
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- 9.** How do paragraphs 1–4 provide an introduction to the rest of Passage 1?
- Ⓐ by emphasizing the damaging effects of small talk
 - Ⓑ by foreshadowing a change in the author’s situation
 - Ⓒ by suggesting the passage will have a lighthearted tone
 - Ⓓ by providing an example of what the author means by small talk

10. How does the phrase “puts my brain to sleep” in paragraph 5 contribute to the mood in Passage 1?

- Ⓐ It creates a relaxed mood by using a metaphor about rest.
- Ⓑ It creates a helpless mood by suggesting the author cannot control her brain.
- Ⓒ It creates a frustrated mood by showing how bored small talk makes the author.
- Ⓓ It creates a thoughtful mood by explaining the science behind how we use language.

- 11.** Select the phrase from paragraph 8 that shows how the author of Passage 1 uses figurative language to convey the idea that small talk is usually formulaic.

8 Basically, the experts are recommending that you Ⓐ break the script and get the other person to improvise. Ⓑ This is the secret that these experts don't want to admit: good conversationalists aren't having Ⓒ better small talk; they're turning small talk into Ⓓ meaningful conversations. But to have that kind of conversation, both people need to be willing participants, and not every stranger or acquaintance wants to Ⓔ have a heart-to-heart or an intellectual debate.

12. How does the rhetorical appeal in paragraph 9 of Passage 1 advance the author's ideas?

- Ⓐ The appeal to logic suggests that there are benefits to accepting quiet moments more often.
- Ⓑ The appeal to authority suggests that the author has thoroughly researched the topic and can be trusted.
- Ⓒ The appeal to emotion suggests that it only makes sense to engage with those who agree with the author.
- Ⓓ The appeal to morality suggests that the author believes keeping quiet is ethically superior to speaking with others.

13. How does the author of Passage 2 appeal to authority to persuade the reader that small talk is valuable?

- Ⓐ by including conversations with experts
- Ⓑ by addressing the issues with a direct plea
- Ⓒ by citing the outcomes of numerous reports
- Ⓓ by listing ideas for improving communication skills

14. Select the word from Passage 2 that comes from the Latin words for “to turn” and “within.”

- 12 Still, Ⓐ bantering with strangers could brighten your morning. In a series of Ⓑ experiments, psychologists gave Chicago commuters varying Ⓒ directions about whether to talk with fellow train passengers—something they typically avoided. Those told to chat with others reported a more pleasant journey than those told to “enjoy your solitude” or to do whatever they Ⓓ normally would. None of the chatters reported being Ⓔ rebuffed. And the results held for Ⓕ introverts and extroverts alike—which makes sense, since acting extroverted has a positive effect on introverts.

15. How does the cause-and-effect structure of paragraphs 12–13 contribute to Passage 2?

- Ⓐ It implies that only silence permits serious thought.
- Ⓑ It challenges the link between solitude and being rejected.
- Ⓒ It shows how engaging in simple conversation can increase happiness.
- Ⓓ It emphasizes the connection between people and what is around them.

16. Read this sentence from Passage 2.

“In one study, people who were rated ‘less curious’ by researchers had trouble getting a conversation rolling on their own, and had greater luck building closeness with others when they were supplied with questions that encouraged personal disclosure (‘When did you last cry in front of someone?’).” (paragraph 14)

What does disclosure mean as it is used in the sentence?

- Ⓐ belonging
- Ⓑ comfort
- Ⓒ growth
- Ⓓ sharing

17. Complete the table to show how the passages develop ideas about small talk.

	Passage 1	Passage 2	Both Passages
states that small talk maintains social relationships	(A)	(B)	(C)
cites evidence that small talk can improve one's mood	(D)	(E)	(F)
notes that small talk is not meant to communicate information	(G)	(H)	(I)

18. Read this sentence from Passage 1.

“This is the secret that these experts don’t want to admit: good conversationalists aren’t having better small talk; they’re turning small talk into meaningful conversations.” (paragraph 8)

Which detail from Passage 2 expresses a similar idea?

- Ⓐ “Late last year, Princeton researchers reported that ring-tailed lemurs reserve their call-and-response conversations, akin to human chitchat, for the animals they groom the most . . .” (paragraph 11)
- Ⓑ “And the results held for introverts and extroverts alike—which makes sense, since acting extroverted has a positive effect on introverts.” (paragraph 12)
- Ⓒ “People who smiled at, made eye contact with, and briefly spoke with their Starbucks baristas reported a greater sense of belonging . . .” (paragraph 13)
- Ⓓ “But people who were deemed ‘curious’ needed no help transforming conversations about mundane things like favorite holidays into intimate exchanges.” (paragraph 14)

- 19.** How does the author of Passage 2 support the central idea that small talk has merit aside from having deeper conversations?
- Ⓐ She includes studies about the fundamental benefits of small talk.
 - Ⓑ She describes that some people are better at small talk than others.
 - Ⓒ She provides examples of the kinds of questions asked in small talk.
 - Ⓓ She compares small talk to substantive talk among college students.

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20. Complete the table to show how each passage develops the idea that small talk has limitations.

	Passage 1	Passage 2	Both Passages
asserts that small talk does not feel genuine or original	(A)	(B)	(C)
states that information conveyed via small talk is superficial	(D)	(E)	(F)
acknowledges that the most content people make the least amount of small talk	(G)	(H)	(I)

Passage 1: Icarus and Daedalus

by Josephine Preston Peabody

- 1 Among all those mortals who grew so wise that they learned the secrets of the gods, none was more cunning than Daedalus.
- 2 He once built, for King Minos of Crete, a wonderful Labyrinth of winding ways so cunningly tangled up and twisted around that, once inside, you could never find your way out again without a magic clue. But the king's favor veered with the wind, and one day he had his master architect imprisoned in a tower. Daedalus managed to escape from his cell; but it seemed impossible to leave the island, since every ship that came or went was well guarded by order of the king.
- 3 At length, watching the sea-gulls in the air—the only creatures that were sure of liberty—he thought of a plan for himself and his young son Icarus, who was captive with him.
- 4 Little by little, he gathered a store of feathers great and small. He fastened these together with thread, moulded them in with wax, and so fashioned two great wings like those of a bird. When they were done, Daedalus fitted them to his own shoulders, and after one or two efforts, he found that by waving his arms he could winnow the air and cleave it, as a swimmer does the sea. He held himself aloft, wavered this way and that with the wind, and at last, like a great fledgling, he learned to fly.
- 5 Without delay, he fell to work on a pair of wings for the boy Icarus, and taught him carefully how to use them, bidding him beware of rash adventures among the stars. "Remember," said the father, "never to fly very low or very high, for the fogs about the earth would weigh you down, but the blaze of the sun will surely melt your feathers apart if you go too near."
- 6 For Icarus, these cautions went in at one ear and out by the other. Who could remember to be careful when he was to fly for the first time? Are birds careful? Not they! And not an idea remained in the boy's head but the one joy of escape.
- 7 The day came, and the fair wind that was to set them free. The father bird put on his wings, and, while the light urged them to be gone, he waited to see that all was well with Icarus, for the two could not fly hand in hand. Up they rose, the boy after his father. The hateful ground of Crete sank beneath them; and the country folk, who caught a glimpse of them when they were high above the tree-tops, took it for a vision of the gods—Apollo, perhaps, with Cupid after him.

- 8 At first there was a terror in the joy. The wide vacancy of the air dazed them—a glance downward made their brains reel. But when a great wind filled their wings, and Icarus felt himself sustained, like a halcyon-bird in the hollow of a wave, like a child uplifted by his mother, he forgot everything in the world but joy. He forgot Crete and the other islands that he had passed over: he saw but vaguely that winged thing in the distance before him that was his father Daedalus. He longed for one draught of flight to quench the thirst of his captivity: he stretched out his arms to the sky and made towards the highest heavens.
- 9 Alas for him! Warmer and warmer grew the air. Those arms, that had seemed to uphold him, relaxed. His wings wavered, drooped. He fluttered his young hands vainly—he was falling—and in that terror he remembered. The heat of the sun had melted the wax from his wings; the feathers were falling, one by one, like snowflakes; and there was none to help.
- 10 He fell like a leaf tossed down the wind, down, down, with one cry that overtook Daedalus far away. When he returned, and sought high and low for the poor boy, he saw nothing but the bird-like feathers afloat on the water.

Excerpt from “Icarus and Daedalus” by Josephine Preston Peabody, from *Old Greek Folk Stories Told Anew*. In the public domain.

Passage 2: Winged Man

by Stephen Vincent Benét

- 1 The cliffs were robed in scarlet, the sands were cinnabar,
Where first two men spread wings for flight and dared the hawk afar.
- There stands the cunning workman, the crafty past all praise,
The man who chained the Minotaur, the man who built the Maze.
- 5 His young son is beside him and the boy’s face is a light,
A light of dawn and wonder and of valor infinite.
- There great vans beat the cloven air, like eagles they mount up,
Motes in the wine of morning, specks in a crystal cup,
And lest his wings should melt apace old Daedalus flies low,
- 10 But Icarus beats up, beats up, he goes where lightnings go.

He cares no more for warnings, he rushes through the sky,
Braving the crags of ether, daring the gods on high,
Black 'gainst the crimson sunset, golden o'er cloudy snows,
With all Adventure in his heart the first winged man arose.

- 15 Dropping gold, dropping gold, where the mists of morning rolled,
On he kept his way undaunted, though his breaths were stabs of cold,
Through the mystery of dawning that no mortal may behold.

- Now he shouts, now he sings in the rapture of his wings,
And his great heart burns intenser with the strength of his desire,
20 As he circles like a swallow, wheeling, flaming, gyre on gyre.

Gazing straight at the sun, half his pilgrimage is done,
And he staggers for a moment, hurries on, reels backward, swerves
In a rain of scattered feathers as he falls in broken curves.

- Icarus, Icarus, though the end is piteous,
25 Yet forever, yea, forever we shall see thee rising thus,
See the first supernal glory, not the ruin hideous.

You were Man, you who ran farther than our eyes can scan,
Man absurd, gigantic, eager for impossible Romance. . . .

- Floating downward, very clear, still the echoes reach the ear
30 Of a little tune he whistles and a little song he sings,
Mounting, mounting still, triumphant, on his torn and broken wings!

Excerpt from "Winged Man" by Stephen Vincent Benét, from *Young Adventure*. In the public domain.

Passage 3: Icarus After the Fall

- The waves slapped Icarus in the face,
a salty sting to his ego.
He had soared so high, he scraped sky blue on his tunic before
35 *SPLASH.*
- He had been having a time peering down on everyone from above,
until his waxed wings began to melt,
and he dropped like a stone,
feathers fluttering behind him,
40 the ocean spread out below like a mirror.

He caught his reflection a moment before he shattered the surface—
eyes bulging,
hair tangled,
forehead bare.

45 *Not exactly a picture for the history books.*

He treaded water, wondering how in the world he would spin this to
old Daedalus.

*I was flying so well, a wind gust caught me, and, and it pushed me up
or better yet*

I saw a dangerous eagle diving towards you, and, and I vanquished it!

50 A disastrous weakness becomes a noble tale.

Would it work? Probably not—

though it might make a decent story to tell his friends.

He plucked at the scattered wax and feathers,
little bobbing bits of his broken pride.

55 *I need to get to shore.*

The man who'd touched the atmosphere had no choice but to swim.

It was then that he heard a voice just behind him,

"Excuse me, sir, do you need a hand?"

A wizened, weathered fisherman in a simple rowboat reached out to help.

60 Icarus blinked a moment and spat a mouthful of ocean
(his fabled smile perfect but not watertight).

"A hand? I don't need any help! Did you not see? I was flying!"

"Icarus After the Fall" written for educational purposes.

21. In paragraph 2 of Passage 1, how does the narrator emphasize the irony of what happens to Daedalus?

- Ⓐ by praising the beauty of Daedalus's Labyrinth while mentioning its danger
- Ⓑ by citing the failure of Daedalus's creations while highlighting other successes
- Ⓒ by criticizing how King Minos treats Daedalus badly at first but then improves his attitude
- Ⓓ by noting how Daedalus wins fame for designing a Labyrinth but then finds himself imprisoned

22. Which phrase from paragraph 8 of Passage 1 creates a mood of delight and enthusiasm?

- Ⓐ The phrase “wide vacancy of the air” implies that the sky where Icarus is flying is otherwise empty.
- Ⓑ The phrase “made their brains reel” explains how Icarus is just learning how to fly.
- Ⓒ The phrase “like a halcyon-bird in the hollow of a wave” emphasizes how Icarus feels as if he is in another world.
- Ⓓ The phrase “saw but vaguely that winged thing in the distance” suggests that Icarus is leaving his father behind.

23. This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

Part A

What universal theme is developed in Passage 1?

- Ⓐ Some inventors create designs inspired by nature.
- Ⓑ Overconfidence can sometimes lead to carelessness.
- Ⓒ Parents and children sometimes come into conflict with each other.
- Ⓓ Some individuals struggle to separate themselves from their parents.

Part B

Which detail from Passage 1 develops the theme in Part A?

- Ⓐ “Without delay, he fell to work on a pair of wings for the boy Icarus, and taught him carefully how to use them, bidding him beware of rash adventures among the stars.” (paragraph 5)
- Ⓑ “And not an idea remained in the boy’s head but the one joy of escape.” (paragraph 6)
- Ⓒ “The hateful ground of Crete sank beneath them; and the country folk, who caught a glimpse of them when they were high above the tree-tops, took it for a vision of the gods—Apollo, perhaps, with Cupid after him.” (paragraph 7)
- Ⓓ “The wide vacancy of the air dazed them—a glance downward made their brains reel.” (paragraph 8)

24. Read these lines from Passage 2.

“The cliffs were robed in scarlet, the sands were cinnabar,” (line 1)

“Black ’gainst the crimson sunset, golden o’er cloudy snows,” (line 13)

“Dropping gold, dropping gold, where the mists of morning rolled,” (line 15)

How does the poet’s style in these lines contribute to the poem’s meaning?

- Ⓐ It emphasizes the vivid landscape of Icarus’s experience.
- Ⓑ It suggests that the actions of Icarus are extremely daring.
- Ⓒ It illustrates Icarus’s confusion as he flies too close to the sun.
- Ⓓ It creates a contrast between the perspectives of Icarus and the speaker.

25. Which line in Passage 3 demonstrates Icarus’s attitude of superiority?

- Ⓐ “He had been having a time peering down on everyone from above,” (line 36)
- Ⓑ “He caught his reflection a moment before he shattered the surface—” (line 41)
- Ⓒ *“Not exactly a picture for the history books.”* (line 45)
- Ⓓ *“I need to get to shore.”* (line 55)

26. How does the poet develop a universal theme in Passage 3?

- Ⓐ Icarus's feelings as he is flying develop the theme that trying something new can bring happiness.
- Ⓑ Icarus's greeting to the old fisherman develops the theme that it is best to accept help when offered.
- Ⓒ Icarus's bragging about flying develops the theme that some people refuse to learn from their mistakes.
- Ⓓ Icarus's attempt at problem solving develops the theme that some people always push themselves to be better.

27. Read these lines from Passage 3.

*"I was flying so well, a wind gust caught me, and, and it pushed me up
or better yet*

*I saw a dangerous eagle diving towards you, and, and I vanquished it!
A disastrous weakness becomes a noble tale."* (lines 47–50)

What does the word "vanquished" in line 49 suggest about Icarus?

- Ⓐ He is embarrassed by his act of overcoming a noble bird.
- Ⓑ He wants other birds to view him as their equal when he is flying.
- Ⓒ He is attempting to make himself appear more of a hero than a failure.
- Ⓓ He hopes that he will face more opportunities to defeat any threatening enemy.

28. Read these lines from Passage 3.

“A wizened, weathered fisherman in a simple rowboat reached out to help. Icarus blinked a moment and spat a mouthful of ocean” (lines 59–60)

How does the speaker’s description of the fisherman and Icarus illustrate the irony of the situation?

- Ⓐ The speaker creates a comical element to lessen the tension between the characters.
- Ⓑ The speaker contrasts the quiet humility of one character to the rude pride of another.
- Ⓒ The speaker stresses the importance of different characters helping one another through a challenge.
- Ⓓ The speaker praises a character making a living from the sea while criticizing a character struggling against it.

29. How does Passage 3 adapt the story of Icarus differently than Passage 2 does?

- Ⓐ In Passage 3, Icarus survives the fall.
- Ⓑ In Passage 3, Icarus seeks sympathy for his failure.
- Ⓒ In Passage 3, Icarus regrets not listening to his father.
- Ⓓ In Passage 3, Icarus acknowledges that he has acted irresponsibly.

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30. Complete the table to show how Passage 2 and Passage 3 adapt the story of Icarus.

	Passage 2	Passage 3	Both Passages
mocks Icarus’s foolishness	Ⓐ	Ⓑ	Ⓒ
admires Icarus and his bold adventure	Ⓓ	Ⓔ	Ⓕ
conveys a message by interpreting Icarus’s action	Ⓖ	Ⓗ	Ⓘ

The Face of Science

by Sam Kean

- 1 It took six minutes, fifty-one seconds for Albert Einstein to become world famous. That's how long the moon stood suspended before the face of the sun on May 29, 1919, eclipsing its light. Mind you, the astronomers below couldn't sail back home and develop their photographs for weeks; they then needed months more to analyze the results. Within those few minutes that spring day, the scientists had captured the first hard proof of Einstein's theory of general relativity—and with that, launched Einstein himself from the darkness of obscurity into the brightness, even glare, of celebrity.
- 2 Success did not come easy to Einstein. He received no job offers upon graduating from college in 1900, and . . . it took four more years to find work as a physicist.
- 3 Professional struggles aside, Einstein's scientific work dissatisfied him as well. His 1905 paper on special relativity had unified two previously incompatible fields, Galileo's laws of motion and Maxwell's laws of electricity and magnetism. But Newton's theory of gravity had resisted integration, and after 1905 Einstein labored for another decade to bring gravity into the fold. Even then, despite how nifty general relativity looked on paper, Einstein's critics complained that there was no proof that it corresponded to reality.
- 4 So, rather audaciously, Einstein proposed a way for scientists to disprove his theory—if they could. Relativity predicted that gravity should bend light. As a result, light from distant stars should curve as it passed by the sun. This, in turn, made the stars' positions in the sky appear shifted compared with their true positions. The sun's brightness made this shift impossible to observe, of course—except during an eclipse, when stars could peek out from behind its shadow. Search for this shift, Einstein declared, and see if I'm right.
- 5 English astronomer Arthur Eddington took Einstein up on this challenge in May 1919, setting up telescopes and cameras on Príncipe, an island off western Africa famed for its cocoa Rain almost scotched the expedition anyway; only an hour before the eclipse did rain clouds lift over Príncipe. And although Eddington scrambled to take sixteen pictures in those six minutes, fifty-one seconds, only two provided useful data.
- 6 Nevertheless, they revealed enough: The stars had shifted. When Eddington finally had these results in hand, he called it the greatest

moment of his life. And he wasn't alone in gushing. Newspapers worldwide jumped on the story: "LIGHT ALL ASKEW IN THE HEAVENS," read one headline, "MEN OF SCIENCE MORE OR LESS AGOG." Even those who couldn't grasp relativity's nuances knew that this Einstein fellow had transformed our understanding of space and time.

- 7 From that moment on, we have lived in Einstein's universe—in more ways than one. Beyond confirming a revolutionary theory, the eclipse inaugurated Einstein as a celebrity, making him the face of science worldwide. . . .
- 8 The hunger for Einstein seems unbelievable in retrospect. Among scientists, a veritable public relations machine of physicists worked to promote general relativity from 1915 onward; six hundred articles and books on it appeared within six years of its debut. The public's hunger proved greater still. A book-length biography of Einstein had appeared by 1921, and he attracted crowds wherever he went, once drawing 15,000 people to Madison Square Garden to celebrate Hanukkah. Churches displayed statues of him, he attended the Rose Bowl parade, and, when he visited Washington, D.C., the U.S. Senate put aside its normal partisan bickering to bicker about relativity theory instead. Einstein appeared on the cover of *Time* on five occasions, and his second wife, Elsa, also got a cover story in *Time*
- 9 Most admirers cheerfully admitted they didn't understand relativity in the slightest. Marcel Proust¹ adored Einstein for upending our notions about how time flows and how we experience time; pity, then, that Proust couldn't make heads or tails of Einstein's algebra. Even many scientists shrugged. After crossing the Atlantic with Einstein in 1921, Chaim Weizmann, a chemist and later the first president of Israel, commented, "Einstein explained his theory to me every day, and by the time we arrived I was fully convinced that he really understands it."
- 10 Einstein found the attention thrust upon him flattering, puzzling, and tiresome all at once. "He loved publicity and loved to complain about it," biographer Walter Isaacson noted in *Einstein: His Life and Universe*. But he always tolerated it, for reasons both noble and grubby. . . .
- 11 Still, Einstein's glamour never faded in the public's eye. He continued to draw crowds wherever he traveled, and whenever he published a new theory, newspaper reporters outdid themselves

¹ Marcel Proust: an influential French novelist

to laud it. In 1929, a London department store even plastered one of his dense, equation-riddled papers in its front window so that crowds could gather around and confirm that, nope, they still didn't understand. That Einstein often ignored these papers later—citing some mistake or misinterpretation and moving on—didn't matter. Reporters fell for it every time and would celebrate the next "breakthrough" with undimmed enthusiasm.

12 Not everyone celebrated Einstein's fame. Colleagues recoiled for the rather quaint reason that publicizing science seemed uncouth. In science, they declared, only ideas matter. . . .

13 A few other scientists in history have achieved celebrity status. Newton and Darwin were buried in London's Westminster Abbey. . . . But no one compares with Albert Einstein. His work strums the deepest chords of our imagination—the nature of time, the origin of the heavens, the ultimate fate of the universe. And he rose to prominence just as new forms of communication made true celebrity status possible. "He came at the moment when almost all the modern media were in place," says Kormos Buchwald. "Newspapers, magazines, photographs, radio. So he was a quintessentially modern scientist in everything, including media exposure."

Excerpt from "The Face of Science" by Sam Kean, from *Humanities Magazine*, May/June 2014, Volume 35, Number 3. In the public domain.

31. This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

Part A

What is a central idea in the passage?

- Ⓐ Einstein's discoveries helped him achieve success early in his career.
- Ⓑ Physicists felt their work was largely ignored by the media and public.
- Ⓒ Einstein's celebrity status made him a unique figure in the scientific field.
- Ⓓ Newspapers featured Einstein alongside famous politicians and celebrities.

Part B

Which detail supports the response in Part A?

- Ⓐ "His 1905 paper on special relativity had unified two previously incompatible fields, Galileo's laws of motion and Maxwell's laws of electricity and magnetism." (paragraph 3)
- Ⓑ "And although Eddington scrambled to take sixteen pictures in those six minutes, fifty-one seconds, only two provided useful data." (paragraph 5)
- Ⓒ "Most admirers cheerfully admitted they didn't understand relativity in the slightest." (paragraph 9)
- Ⓓ "He continued to draw crowds wherever he traveled, and whenever he published a new theory, newspaper reporters outdid themselves to laud it." (paragraph 11)

32. How do the title of the passage and paragraph 7 reflect the author's overall purpose?

- Ⓐ by emphasizing how Einstein came to symbolize scientific discovery
- Ⓑ by summarizing how different scientists reacted to Einstein's theories
- Ⓒ by sharing how popular magazines published about Einstein in the past
- Ⓓ by pointing out how different Einstein was from the public's perception of him

33. Select **two** ways paragraphs 5 and 6 develop ideas about Einstein in the passage.

- Ⓐ They indicate how global leaders took notice of Einstein's previous theories.
- Ⓑ They demonstrate how other scientists verified Einstein's theory of relativity.
- Ⓒ They highlight how a single experiment changed the course of Einstein's career.
- Ⓓ They show how Einstein's scientific ideas created more questions than answers.
- Ⓔ They describe how science has changed since the time when Einstein began his career.

34. This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

Part A

What central idea about the media does the author develop in the passage?

- Ⓐ Media's expanding influence helped create Einstein's fame.
- Ⓑ Media journalists ignored criticism in order to write about Einstein.
- Ⓒ Media's positive reputation encouraged readers to buy Einstein's papers.
- Ⓓ Media organizations limited coverage of science due to other popular world events.

Part B

How does the author develop the central idea in Part A?

- Ⓐ by implying that publications were reluctant to hold Einstein accountable
- Ⓑ by naming international publications that featured Einstein on their covers
- Ⓒ by describing the different forms of media that covered Einstein and his work
- Ⓓ by summarizing how Einstein felt about the attention he received from the media

35. Why does the author point out the irony in Einstein's perspective in paragraph 10?

- Ⓐ to explain why other scientists at the time resented Einstein's success
- Ⓑ to describe why Einstein became reluctant to continue working in the public eye
- Ⓒ to show that Einstein had less interest in his celebrity status than the public did
- Ⓓ to demonstrate that Einstein came up with theories based on whether they would be accepted

36. This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

Part A

Why does the author suggest that novelist Marcel Proust “couldn’t make heads or tails of Einstein’s algebra” (paragraph 9)?

- Ⓐ to point out how two academic figures in the past had a friendly relationship
- Ⓑ to show how people used to share mathematical discoveries with one another
- Ⓒ to highlight how Einstein struggled to have his ideas proved by other scientists
- Ⓓ to comment on how people admired Einstein’s work without really understanding it

Part B

How does the response in Part A connect to the role of the media in the passage?

- Ⓐ It supports how authors resisted publishing Einstein’s papers.
- Ⓑ It describes how individuals celebrated Einstein’s scientific breakthroughs.
- Ⓒ It shows how other scientists tried to compete with Einstein’s level of publicity.
- Ⓓ It demonstrates how others tried to use Einstein’s popularity for their own benefit.



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Test Release: 2025

A White Heron

by Sarah Orne Jewett

In this excerpt of a short story set in rural Maine in the late 1800s, a young girl named Sylvia meets a young man studying birds. He is trying to find a rare bird, the white heron. This scene starts with the young man speaking to Mrs. Tilley, Sylvia's grandmother.

- 1 "I caught a glimpse of a white heron a few miles from here on Saturday, and I have followed it in this direction. They have never been found in this district at all. The little white heron, it is," and he turned again to look at Sylvia with the hope of discovering that the rare bird was one of her acquaintances.
- 2 But Sylvia was watching a hop-toad in the narrow footpath.
- 3 "You would know the heron if you saw it," the stranger continued eagerly. "A queer tall white bird with soft feathers and long thin legs. And it would have a nest perhaps in the top of a high tree, made of sticks, something like a hawk's nest."
- 4 Sylvia's heart gave a wild beat; she knew that strange white bird, and had once stolen softly near where it stood in some bright green swamp grass, away over at the other side of the woods. There was an open place where the sunshine always seemed strangely yellow and hot, where tall, nodding rushes grew, and her grandmother had warned her that she might sink in the soft black mud underneath Not far beyond were the salt marshes just this side the sea itself, which Sylvia wondered and dreamed much about, but never had seen, whose great voice could sometimes be heard above the noise of the woods on stormy nights.
- 5 "I can't think of anything I should like so much as to find that heron's nest," the handsome stranger was saying. "I would give ten dollars to anybody who could show it to me," he added desperately, "and I mean to spend my whole vacation hunting for it if need be. Perhaps it was only migrating, or had been chased out of its own region by some bird of prey."
- 6 Mrs. Tilley gave amazed attention to all this, but Sylvia still watched the toad, not divining, as she might have done at some calmer time, that the creature wished to get to its hole under the door-step, and was much hindered by the unusual spectators at that hour of the evening. No amount of thought, that night, could decide how many wished-for treasures the ten dollars, so lightly spoken of, would buy.

- 7 The next day the young sportsman hovered about the woods, and Sylvia kept him company, having lost her first fear of the friendly lad, who proved to be most kind and sympathetic. He told her many things about the birds and what they knew and where they lived and what they did with themselves. And he gave her a jack-knife, which she thought as great a treasure as if she were a desert-islander. All day long he did not once make her troubled or afraid except when he brought down some unsuspecting singing creature from its bough. . . . But as the day waned, Sylvia still watched the young man with loving admiration. She had never seen anybody so charming and delightful They stopped to listen to a bird's song; they pressed forward again eagerly, parting the branches—speaking to each other rarely and in whispers; the young man going first and Sylvia following, fascinated, a few steps behind, with her gray eyes dark with excitement.
- 8 She grieved because the longed-for white heron was elusive, but she did not lead the guest, she only followed, and there was no such thing as speaking first. The sound of her own unquestioned voice would have terrified her—it was hard enough to answer yes or no when there was need of that. At last evening began to fall, and they drove the cow home together, and Sylvia smiled with pleasure when they came to the place where she heard the whistle and was afraid only the night before.
- 9 Half a mile from home, at the farther edge of the woods, where the land was highest, a great pine-tree stood, the last of its generation. Whether it was left for a boundary mark, or for what reason, no one could say; the woodchoppers who had felled its mates were dead and gone long ago, and a whole forest of sturdy trees, pines and oaks and maples, had grown again. But the stately head of this old pine towered above them all and made a landmark for sea and shore miles and miles away. Sylvia knew it well. She had always believed that whoever climbed to the top of it could see the ocean; and the little girl had often laid her hand on the great rough trunk and looked up wistfully at those dark boughs that the wind always stirred, no matter how hot and still the air might be below. Now she thought of the tree with a new excitement, for why, if one climbed it at break of day could not one see all the world, and easily discover from whence the white heron flew, and mark the place, and find the hidden nest?
- 10 What a spirit of adventure, what wild ambition! What fancied triumph and delight and glory for the later morning when she could make known the secret! It was almost too real and too great for the childish heart to bear.

- 11 All night the door of the little house stood open and the whippoorwills came and sang upon the very step. The young sportsman and his old hostess were sound asleep, but Sylvia's great design kept her broad awake and watching. She forgot to think of sleep. The short summer night seemed as long as the winter darkness, and at last when the whippoorwills ceased, and she was afraid the morning would after all come too soon, she stole out of the house and followed the pasture path through the woods, hastening toward the open ground beyond, listening with a sense of comfort and companionship to the drowsy twitter of a half-awakened bird, whose perch she had jarred in passing. Alas, if the great wave of human interest which flooded for the first time this dull little life should sweep away the satisfactions of an existence heart to heart with nature and the dumb life of the forest!

Excerpt from "A White Heron" by Sarah Orne Jewett. In the public domain.

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1. How do the descriptions of the heron in paragraphs 1–3 contribute to the plot of the passage?
- Ⓐ They indicate why the heron is unique.
 - Ⓑ They foreshadow how the heron will be found.
 - Ⓒ They introduce different opinions on the heron.
 - Ⓓ They suggest that many people care about the heron.

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 62%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.1.1

Benchmark Description: Explain how key elements enhance or add layers of meaning and/or style in a literary text.

2. Read this sentence from the passage.

“Not far beyond were the salt marshes just this side the sea itself, which Sylvia wondered and dreamed much about, but never had seen, whose great voice could sometimes be heard above the noise of the woods on stormy nights.” (paragraph 4)

How does the personification of the sea affect the mood of the passage?

- ☒ Ⓐ The magnificence of the sound creates an intriguing mood.
- ☐ Ⓑ The treacherousness of the storms creates an uneasy mood.
- ☐ Ⓒ The contrast between dreams and reality creates a hopeful mood.
- ☐ Ⓓ The distance between the woods and the water creates a lonely mood.

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 52%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.3.1

Benchmark Description: Explain how figurative language creates mood in text(s).

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3. How does paragraph 4 develop irony?

- Ⓐ by revealing that Sylvia knows more about the bird than she says aloud
- Ⓑ by revealing that the terrain is more varied than an outsider might assume
- Ⓒ by revealing that the area is more dangerous than it might initially appear to be
- Ⓓ by revealing that Sylvia is more curious about the young man than she pretends to be

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 47%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.1.3

Benchmark Description: Analyze the influence of narrator perspective on a text, explaining how the author creates irony or satire.

4. Read these sentences from the passage.

“But as the day waned, Sylvia still watched the young man with loving admiration. She had never seen anybody so charming and delightful . . .”
(paragraph 7)

How does the exaggeration “She had never seen anybody so charming and delightful” contribute to the sense of cheerfulness in the paragraph?

- Ⓐ It implies that Sylvia likes to make friends.
- Ⓑ It reflects the enthusiasm that Sylvia feels.
- Ⓒ It implies that the young man knows Sylvia well.
- Ⓓ It reflects the fanciful nature of what Sylvia wants.

Answer Key: B

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 71%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.3.1

Benchmark Description: Explain how figurative language creates mood in text(s).

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5. Read this sentence from the passage.

“Now she thought of the tree with a new excitement, for why, if one climbed it at break of day could not one see all the world, and easily discover from whence the white heron flew, and mark the place, and find the hidden nest?” (paragraph 9)

How does this rhetorical question contribute to the passage?

- Ⓐ It reveals Sylvia’s desire to avoid returning home.
- Ⓑ It highlights Sylvia’s desire to learn more about local plant life.
- Ⓒ It reveals Sylvia’s confidence in being able to find the white heron.
- Ⓓ It highlights Sylvia’s frustration at not locating the white heron yet.

Answer Key: C

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 66%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.3.4

Benchmark Description: Explain an author’s use of rhetoric in a text.

6. Read this sentence.

“The short summer night seemed as long as the winter darkness, and at last when the whippoorwills ceased, and she was afraid the morning would after all come too soon, she stole out of the house and followed the pasture path through the woods, hastening toward the open ground beyond, listening with a sense of comfort and companionship to the drowsy twitter of a half-awakened bird, whose perch she had jarred in passing.” (paragraph 11)

What is the meaning of jarred as it is used in the sentence?

- ☒ Ⓐ bumped
- ☐ Ⓑ opened
- ☐ Ⓒ ruined
- ☐ Ⓓ stored

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 47%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.9.V.1.3

Benchmark Description: Apply knowledge of context clues, figurative language, word relationships, reference materials, and/or background knowledge to determine the connotative and denotative meaning of words and phrases, appropriate to grade level.

7. Read this paragraph.

10 What a spirit of adventure, what wild ambition! What fancied triumph and delight and glory for the later morning when she could make known the secret! It was almost too real and too great for the childish heart to bear.

How does this paragraph contribute to the universal theme about the joys of childhood in the passage?

- ☒ Ⓐ by highlighting how some emotions can feel overwhelming
- ☐ Ⓑ by implying that searching for glory is an immature ambition
- ☐ Ⓒ by highlighting how the future always seems more promising than the present
- ☐ Ⓓ by implying that secrets can undermine the strength of important relationships

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 48%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.1.2

Benchmark Description: Analyze universal themes and their development throughout a literary text.

- 8.** This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

Part A

Which universal theme does the passage develop?

- ☒ Ⓐ People can quickly form a bond over shared goals.
- ☐ Ⓑ People should share their knowledge with each other.
- ☐ Ⓒ People can pass on their wisdom to future generations.
- ☐ Ⓓ People should work together to protect the environment.

Part B

Which relationship in the passage develops the universal theme in Part A?

- ☐ Ⓐ Sylvia's respect for the bird
- ☒ Ⓑ Sylvia's interest in the young man
- ☐ Ⓒ Sylvia's devotion to her grandmother
- ☐ Ⓓ Sylvia's concern for the environment

Answer Key: A and B

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 38%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.1.2

Benchmark Description: Analyze universal themes and their development throughout a literary text.

Passage 1: Small Talk Is Overrated

1 “Hi! How are you?”

2 “Good. How about you?”

3 “Good. How about this weather?”

4 “I know, it’s so gorgeous outside, but tomorrow it’s supposed to rain.”

5 So it begins—the conversation that I’ve had one thousand times. This kind of inane small talk puts my brain to sleep. Even though small talk is a ritual that is supposed to make talking to strangers and acquaintances easier, it really hinders my ability to connect with other people. It becomes consuming, the way a simple question turns into a five-minute conversation about nothing. Small talk has infiltrated every part of my life, too. I found myself asking my great-uncle how work was at the last family gathering. He’s been retired for seven years, but the question popped up like a reflex.

6 Why is small talk so terrible? For me, the problem is that it feels fake and repetitive. We ask questions where the answer is either obvious or trivial, and the answers are practically scripted. The anthropological term for these kinds of conversations is a “phatic expression.” Phatic expressions are meant to create or maintain social relationships, not convey information. So small talk is meaningful *because* it’s meaningless? That feels backwards. Why not just skip the formalities and have a genuine conversation instead?

7 I don’t think I’m alone in wanting more interesting conversations. There are hundreds of thousands of articles online about how to get better at small talk, which suggests that many people are looking for alternatives. Most social etiquette “experts” will recommend some combination of the following:

- Asking your conversation partner questions because people love talking about themselves
- Being an active listener who expresses interest in what your conversation partner says
- Elaborating on your answers so that your conversation partner has more information to respond to

8 Basically, the experts are recommending that you break the script and get the other person to improvise. This is the secret that these experts don’t want to admit: good conversationalists aren’t having better small talk; they’re turning small talk into meaningful conversations. But to have that kind of conversation, both people need to be willing participants, and not every stranger or acquaintance wants to have a heart-to-heart or an intellectual debate.

- 9 There is an alternate solution: companionable silence. So often, we describe silence as “uncomfortable” or “awkward,” but we should embrace these quiet moments instead. Pressure to socially conform has been shown to contribute to stress and anxiety. If we could accept silence as natural, a lot of talking just for the sake of it could be avoided. Sometimes, there just isn’t anything that needs to be said.

“Small Talk Is Overrated” written for educational purposes.

Passage 2: Do People Need Small Talk to Be Happy?

by Stephanie Hayes

- 10 Psychologists have long said that connecting with others is central to well-being, but just how much conversation we require is under investigation. In one study, researchers eavesdropped on undergraduates for four days, then cataloged each overheard conversation as either “small talk” (“What do you have there? Popcorn? Yummy!”) or “substantive” (“So did they get divorced soon after?”). They found that the second type correlated with happiness—the happiest students had roughly twice as many substantive talks as the unhappiest ones. Small talk, meanwhile, made up only 10 percent of their conversation, versus almost 30 percent of conversation among the least content students.
- 11 But don’t write off chitchat just yet. Scientists believe that small talk (which linguists describe as a form of “phatic communication”) could promote bonding. Late last year, Princeton researchers reported that ring-tailed lemurs reserve their call-and-response conversations, akin to human chitchat, for the animals they groom the most—suggesting that small talk maintains closeness with loved ones, and isn’t merely the stuff of awkward exchanges with strangers.
- 12 Still, bantering with strangers could brighten your morning. In a series of experiments, psychologists gave Chicago commuters varying directions about whether to talk with fellow train passengers—something they typically avoided. Those told to chat with others reported a more pleasant journey than those told to “enjoy your solitude” or to do whatever they normally would. None of the chatters reported being rebuffed. And the results held for introverts and extroverts alike—which makes sense, since acting extroverted has a positive effect on introverts.
- 13 Small talk can also help us feel connected to our surroundings. People who smiled at, made eye contact with, and briefly spoke with

their Starbucks baristas reported a greater sense of belonging than those who rushed through the transaction. Similarly, one not yet published paper found that when volunteers broke the silence of the Tate Modern¹ to chat with gallerygoers, the visitors felt happier and more connected to the exhibit than those who were not approached.

14 Of course, some of us are better than others at turning small talk into something bigger. In one study, people who were rated “less curious” by researchers had trouble getting a conversation rolling on their own, and had greater luck building closeness with others when they were supplied with questions that encouraged personal disclosure (“When did you last cry in front of someone?”). But people who were deemed “curious” needed no help transforming conversations about mundane things like favorite holidays into intimate exchanges. A “curious mind-set,” the authors concluded, can lead to “positive social interactions.”

15 So go ahead, pry. Chitchat needn’t be idle. And nosiness isn’t all bad.

¹ Tate Modern: an art museum in London, England

Excerpt from “Do People Need Small Talk to Be Happy?” by Stephanie Hayes, from *The Atlantic*. Copyright © 2016 by The Atlantic Monthly Group. Reprinted by permission of The Atlantic Monthly Group via Copyright Clearance Center.

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9. How do paragraphs 1–4 provide an introduction to the rest of Passage 1?
- Ⓐ by emphasizing the damaging effects of small talk
 - Ⓑ by foreshadowing a change in the author’s situation
 - Ⓒ by suggesting the passage will have a lighthearted tone
 - Ⓓ by providing an example of what the author means by small talk

Answer Key: D

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 82%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.2.1

Benchmark Description: Analyze how multiple text structures and/or features convey a purpose and/or meaning in texts.

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- 10.** How does the phrase “puts my brain to sleep” in paragraph 5 contribute to the mood in Passage 1?
- Ⓐ It creates a relaxed mood by using a metaphor about rest.
 - Ⓑ It creates a helpless mood by suggesting the author cannot control her brain.
 - Ⓒ It creates a frustrated mood by showing how bored small talk makes the author.
 - Ⓓ It creates a thoughtful mood by explaining the science behind how we use language.

Answer Key: C

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 78%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.3.1

Benchmark Description: Explain how figurative language creates mood in text(s).

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- 11.** Select the phrase from paragraph 8 that shows how the author of Passage 1 uses figurative language to convey the idea that small talk is usually formulaic.

8 Basically, the experts are recommending that you Ⓐ break the script and get the other person to improvise. Ⓑ This is the secret that these experts don't want to admit: good conversationalists aren't having Ⓒ better small talk; they're turning small talk into Ⓓ meaningful conversations. But to have that kind of conversation, both people need to be willing participants, and not every stranger or acquaintance wants to Ⓔ have a heart-to-heart or an intellectual debate.

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 56%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.3.4

Benchmark Description: Explain an author's use of rhetoric in a text.

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12. How does the rhetorical appeal in paragraph 9 of Passage 1 advance the author's ideas?

- Ⓐ The appeal to logic suggests that there are benefits to accepting quiet moments more often.
- Ⓑ The appeal to authority suggests that the author has thoroughly researched the topic and can be trusted.
- Ⓒ The appeal to emotion suggests that it only makes sense to engage with those who agree with the author.
- Ⓓ The appeal to morality suggests that the author believes keeping quiet is ethically superior to speaking with others.

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 66%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.3.4

Benchmark Description: Explain an author's use of rhetoric in a text.

13. How does the author of Passage 2 appeal to authority to persuade the reader that small talk is valuable?

- Ⓐ by including conversations with experts
- Ⓑ by addressing the issues with a direct plea
- Ⓒ by citing the outcomes of numerous reports
- Ⓓ by listing ideas for improving communication skills

Answer Key: C

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 51%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.2.3

Benchmark Description: Analyze how an author establishes and achieves purpose(s) through rhetorical appeals and/or figurative language.

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14. Select the word from Passage 2 that comes from the Latin words for “to turn” and “within.”

- 12 Still, Ⓐ bantering with strangers could brighten your morning. In a series of Ⓑ experiments, psychologists gave Chicago commuters varying Ⓒ directions about whether to talk with fellow train passengers—something they typically avoided. Those told to chat with others reported a more pleasant journey than those told to “enjoy your solitude” or to do whatever they Ⓓ normally would. None of the chatters reported being Ⓔ rebuffed. And the results held for Ⓕ introverts and extroverts alike—which makes sense, since acting extroverted has a positive effect on introverts.

Answer Key: F

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 36%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.9.V.1.2

Benchmark Description: Apply knowledge of etymology and derivations to determine meanings of words and phrases in grade-level content.

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15. How does the cause-and-effect structure of paragraphs 12–13 contribute to Passage 2?

- Ⓐ It implies that only silence permits serious thought.
- Ⓑ It challenges the link between solitude and being rejected.
- Ⓒ It shows how engaging in simple conversation can increase happiness.
- Ⓓ It emphasizes the connection between people and what is around them.

Answer Key: C

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 66%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.2.1

Benchmark Description: Analyze how multiple text structures and/or features convey a purpose and/or meaning in texts.

Grade 9 FAST ELA Reading Test Release Support Document

16. Read this sentence from Passage 2.

“In one study, people who were rated ‘less curious’ by researchers had trouble getting a conversation rolling on their own, and had greater luck building closeness with others when they were supplied with questions that encouraged personal disclosure (‘When did you last cry in front of someone?’).” (paragraph 14)

What does disclosure mean as it is used in the sentence?

- Ⓐ belonging
- Ⓑ comfort
- Ⓒ growth
- Ⓓ sharing

Answer Key: D

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 52%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.9.V.1.3

Benchmark Description: Apply knowledge of context clues, figurative language, word relationships, reference materials, and/or background knowledge to determine the connotative and denotative meaning of words and phrases, appropriate to grade level.

Grade 9 FAST ELA Reading Test Release Support Document

17. Complete the table to show how the passages develop ideas about small talk.

	Passage 1	Passage 2	Both Passages
states that small talk maintains social relationships	(A)	(B)	(C)
cites evidence that small talk can improve one's mood	(D)	(E)	(F)
notes that small talk is not meant to communicate information	(G)	(H)	(I)

Answer Key: C, E, G

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 39%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.2.4

Benchmark Description: Compare the development of two opposing arguments on the same topic, evaluating the effectiveness and validity of the claims.

18. Read this sentence from Passage 1.

“This is the secret that these experts don’t want to admit: good conversationalists aren’t having better small talk; they’re turning small talk into meaningful conversations.” (paragraph 8)

Which detail from Passage 2 expresses a similar idea?

- Ⓐ “Late last year, Princeton researchers reported that ring-tailed lemurs reserve their call-and-response conversations, akin to human chitchat, for the animals they groom the most . . .” (paragraph 11)
- Ⓑ “And the results held for introverts and extroverts alike—which makes sense, since acting extroverted has a positive effect on introverts.” (paragraph 12)
- Ⓒ “People who smiled at, made eye contact with, and briefly spoke with their Starbucks baristas reported a greater sense of belonging . . .” (paragraph 13)
- Ⓓ “But people who were deemed ‘curious’ needed no help transforming conversations about mundane things like favorite holidays into intimate exchanges.” (paragraph 14)

Answer Key: D

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 58%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.2.4

Benchmark Description: Compare the development of two opposing arguments on the same topic, evaluating the effectiveness and validity of the claims.

19. How does the author of Passage 2 support the central idea that small talk has merit aside from having deeper conversations?

- Ⓐ She includes studies about the fundamental benefits of small talk.
- Ⓑ She describes that some people are better at small talk than others.
- Ⓒ She provides examples of the kinds of questions asked in small talk.
- Ⓓ She compares small talk to substantive talk among college students.

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 55%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.2.2

Benchmark Description: Evaluate the support an author uses to develop the central idea(s) throughout a text.

Grade 9 FAST ELA Reading Test Release Support Document

- 20.** Complete the table to show how each passage develops the idea that small talk has limitations.

	Passage 1	Passage 2	Both Passages
asserts that small talk does not feel genuine or original	(A)	(B)	(C)
states that information conveyed via small talk is superficial	(D)	(E)	(F)
acknowledges that the most content people make the least amount of small talk	(G)	(H)	(I)

Answer Key: A, F, H

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 29%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.2.4

Benchmark Description: Compare the development of two opposing arguments on the same topic, evaluating the effectiveness and validity of the claims.

Passage 1: Icarus and Daedalus

by Josephine Preston Peabody

- 1 Among all those mortals who grew so wise that they learned the secrets of the gods, none was more cunning than Daedalus.
- 2 He once built, for King Minos of Crete, a wonderful Labyrinth of winding ways so cunningly tangled up and twisted around that, once inside, you could never find your way out again without a magic clue. But the king's favor veered with the wind, and one day he had his master architect imprisoned in a tower. Daedalus managed to escape from his cell; but it seemed impossible to leave the island, since every ship that came or went was well guarded by order of the king.
- 3 At length, watching the sea-gulls in the air—the only creatures that were sure of liberty—he thought of a plan for himself and his young son Icarus, who was captive with him.
- 4 Little by little, he gathered a store of feathers great and small. He fastened these together with thread, moulded them in with wax, and so fashioned two great wings like those of a bird. When they were done, Daedalus fitted them to his own shoulders, and after one or two efforts, he found that by waving his arms he could winnow the air and cleave it, as a swimmer does the sea. He held himself aloft, wavered this way and that with the wind, and at last, like a great fledgling, he learned to fly.
- 5 Without delay, he fell to work on a pair of wings for the boy Icarus, and taught him carefully how to use them, bidding him beware of rash adventures among the stars. "Remember," said the father, "never to fly very low or very high, for the fogs about the earth would weigh you down, but the blaze of the sun will surely melt your feathers apart if you go too near."
- 6 For Icarus, these cautions went in at one ear and out by the other. Who could remember to be careful when he was to fly for the first time? Are birds careful? Not they! And not an idea remained in the boy's head but the one joy of escape.
- 7 The day came, and the fair wind that was to set them free. The father bird put on his wings, and, while the light urged them to be gone, he waited to see that all was well with Icarus, for the two could not fly hand in hand. Up they rose, the boy after his father. The hateful ground of Crete sank beneath them; and the country folk, who caught a glimpse of them when they were high above the tree-tops, took it for a vision of the gods—Apollo, perhaps, with Cupid after him.

- 8 At first there was a terror in the joy. The wide vacancy of the air dazed them—a glance downward made their brains reel. But when a great wind filled their wings, and Icarus felt himself sustained, like a halcyon-bird in the hollow of a wave, like a child uplifted by his mother, he forgot everything in the world but joy. He forgot Crete and the other islands that he had passed over: he saw but vaguely that winged thing in the distance before him that was his father Daedalus. He longed for one draught of flight to quench the thirst of his captivity: he stretched out his arms to the sky and made towards the highest heavens.
- 9 Alas for him! Warmer and warmer grew the air. Those arms, that had seemed to uphold him, relaxed. His wings wavered, drooped. He fluttered his young hands vainly—he was falling—and in that terror he remembered. The heat of the sun had melted the wax from his wings; the feathers were falling, one by one, like snowflakes; and there was none to help.
- 10 He fell like a leaf tossed down the wind, down, down, with one cry that overtook Daedalus far away. When he returned, and sought high and low for the poor boy, he saw nothing but the bird-like feathers afloat on the water.

Excerpt from “Icarus and Daedalus” by Josephine Preston Peabody, from *Old Greek Folk Stories Told Anew*. In the public domain.

Passage 2: Winged Man

by Stephen Vincent Benét

- 1 The cliffs were robed in scarlet, the sands were cinnabar,
Where first two men spread wings for flight and dared the hawk afar.
- There stands the cunning workman, the crafty past all praise,
The man who chained the Minotaur, the man who built the Maze.
- 5 His young son is beside him and the boy's face is a light,
A light of dawn and wonder and of valor infinite.
- There great vans beat the cloven air, like eagles they mount up,
Motes in the wine of morning, specks in a crystal cup,
And lest his wings should melt apace old Daedalus flies low,
- 10 But Icarus beats up, beats up, he goes where lightnings go.

He cares no more for warnings, he rushes through the sky,
Braving the crags of ether, daring the gods on high,
Black 'gainst the crimson sunset, golden o'er cloudy snows,
With all Adventure in his heart the first winged man arose.

- 15 Dropping gold, dropping gold, where the mists of morning rolled,
On he kept his way undaunted, though his breaths were stabs of cold,
Through the mystery of dawning that no mortal may behold.

- Now he shouts, now he sings in the rapture of his wings,
And his great heart burns intenser with the strength of his desire,
20 As he circles like a swallow, wheeling, flaming, gyre on gyre.

Gazing straight at the sun, half his pilgrimage is done,
And he staggers for a moment, hurries on, reels backward, swerves
In a rain of scattered feathers as he falls in broken curves.

- Icarus, Icarus, though the end is piteous,
25 Yet forever, yea, forever we shall see thee rising thus,
See the first supernal glory, not the ruin hideous.

You were Man, you who ran farther than our eyes can scan,
Man absurd, gigantic, eager for impossible Romance. . . .

- Floating downward, very clear, still the echoes reach the ear
30 Of a little tune he whistles and a little song he sings,
Mounting, mounting still, triumphant, on his torn and broken wings!

Excerpt from "Winged Man" by Stephen Vincent Benét, from *Young Adventure*. In the public domain.

Passage 3: Icarus After the Fall

- The waves slapped Icarus in the face,
a salty sting to his ego.
He had soared so high, he scraped sky blue on his tunic before
35 *SPLASH.*
- He had been having a time peering down on everyone from above,
until his waxed wings began to melt,
and he dropped like a stone,
feathers fluttering behind him,
40 the ocean spread out below like a mirror.

- He caught his reflection a moment before he shattered the surface—
eyes bulging,
hair tangled,
forehead bare.
- 45 *Not exactly a picture for the history books.*
- He treaded water, wondering how in the world he would spin this to
old Daedalus.
*I was flying so well, a wind gust caught me, and, and it pushed me up
or better yet
I saw a dangerous eagle diving towards you, and, and I vanquished it!*
- 50 A disastrous weakness becomes a noble tale.
- Would it work? Probably not—
though it might make a decent story to tell his friends.
He plucked at the scattered wax and feathers,
little bobbing bits of his broken pride.
- 55 *I need to get to shore.*
The man who'd touched the atmosphere had no choice but to swim.
- It was then that he heard a voice just behind him,
"Excuse me, sir, do you need a hand?"
A wizened, weathered fisherman in a simple rowboat reached out to help.
- 60 Icarus blinked a moment and spat a mouthful of ocean
(his fabled smile perfect but not watertight).
- "A hand? I don't need any help! Did you not see? I was flying!"

"Icarus After the Fall" written for educational purposes.

21. In paragraph 2 of Passage 1, how does the narrator emphasize the irony of what happens to Daedalus?

- Ⓐ by praising the beauty of Daedalus's Labyrinth while mentioning its danger
- Ⓑ by citing the failure of Daedalus's creations while highlighting other successes
- Ⓒ by criticizing how King Minos treats Daedalus badly at first but then improves his attitude
- Ⓓ by noting how Daedalus wins fame for designing a Labyrinth but then finds himself imprisoned

Answer Key: D

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 54%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.1.3

Benchmark Description: Analyze the influence of narrator perspective on a text, explaining how the author creates irony or satire.

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- 22.** Which phrase from paragraph 8 of Passage 1 creates a mood of delight and enthusiasm?
- Ⓐ The phrase “wide vacancy of the air” implies that the sky where Icarus is flying is otherwise empty.
 - Ⓑ The phrase “made their brains reel” explains how Icarus is just learning how to fly.
 - Ⓒ The phrase “like a halcyon-bird in the hollow of a wave” emphasizes how Icarus feels as if he is in another world.
 - Ⓓ The phrase “saw but vaguely that winged thing in the distance” suggests that Icarus is leaving his father behind.

Answer Key: C

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 71%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.3.1

Benchmark Description: Explain how figurative language creates mood in text(s).

23. This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

Part A

What universal theme is developed in Passage 1?

- Ⓐ Some inventors create designs inspired by nature.
- Ⓑ Overconfidence can sometimes lead to carelessness.
- Ⓒ Parents and children sometimes come into conflict with each other.
- Ⓓ Some individuals struggle to separate themselves from their parents.

Part B

Which detail from Passage 1 develops the theme in Part A?

- Ⓐ “Without delay, he fell to work on a pair of wings for the boy Icarus, and taught him carefully how to use them, bidding him beware of rash adventures among the stars.” (paragraph 5)
- Ⓑ “And not an idea remained in the boy’s head but the one joy of escape.” (paragraph 6)
- Ⓒ “The hateful ground of Crete sank beneath them; and the country folk, who caught a glimpse of them when they were high above the tree-tops, took it for a vision of the gods—Apollo, perhaps, with Cupid after him.” (paragraph 7)
- Ⓓ “The wide vacancy of the air dazed them—a glance downward made their brains reel.” (paragraph 8)

Answer Key: B and B

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 47%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.1.2

Benchmark Description: Analyze universal themes and their development throughout a literary text.

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24. Read these lines from Passage 2.

“The cliffs were robed in scarlet, the sands were cinnabar,” (line 1)

“Black ’gainst the crimson sunset, golden o’er cloudy snows,” (line 13)

“Dropping gold, dropping gold, where the mists of morning rolled,” (line 15)

How does the poet’s style in these lines contribute to the poem’s meaning?

- ☒ Ⓐ It emphasizes the vivid landscape of Icarus’s experience.
- ☐ Ⓑ It suggests that the actions of Icarus are extremely daring.
- ☐ Ⓒ It illustrates Icarus’s confusion as he flies too close to the sun.
- ☐ Ⓓ It creates a contrast between the perspectives of Icarus and the speaker.

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 67%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.1.1

Benchmark Description: Explain how key elements enhance or add layers of meaning and/or style in a literary text.

25. Which line in Passage 3 demonstrates Icarus’s attitude of superiority?

- Ⓐ “He had been having a time peering down on everyone from above,” (line 36)
- Ⓑ “He caught his reflection a moment before he shattered the surface—” (line 41)
- Ⓒ “*Not exactly a picture for the history books.*” (line 45)
- Ⓓ “*I need to get to shore.*” (line 55)

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 73%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.1.1

Benchmark Description: Explain how key elements enhance or add layers of meaning and/or style in a literary text.

26. How does the poet develop a universal theme in Passage 3?

- Ⓐ Icarus's feelings as he is flying develop the theme that trying something new can bring happiness.
- Ⓑ Icarus's greeting to the old fisherman develops the theme that it is best to accept help when offered.
- Ⓒ Icarus's bragging about flying develops the theme that some people refuse to learn from their mistakes.
- Ⓓ Icarus's attempt at problem solving develops the theme that some people always push themselves to be better.

Answer Key: C

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 56%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.1.2

Benchmark Description: Analyze universal themes and their development throughout a literary text.

27. Read these lines from Passage 3.

*"I was flying so well, a wind gust caught me, and, and it pushed me up or better yet
I saw a dangerous eagle diving towards you, and, and I vanquished it!
A disastrous weakness becomes a noble tale."* (lines 47–50)

What does the word "vanquished" in line 49 suggest about Icarus?

- Ⓐ He is embarrassed by his act of overcoming a noble bird.
- Ⓑ He wants other birds to view him as their equal when he is flying.
- Ⓒ He is attempting to make himself appear more of a hero than a failure.
- Ⓓ He hopes that he will face more opportunities to defeat any threatening enemy.

Answer Key: C

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 72%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.9.V.1.3

Benchmark Description: Apply knowledge of context clues, figurative language, word relationships, reference materials, and/or background knowledge to determine the connotative and denotative meaning of words and phrases, appropriate to grade level.

28. Read these lines from Passage 3.

“A wizened, weathered fisherman in a simple rowboat reached out to help. Icarus blinked a moment and spat a mouthful of ocean” (lines 59–60)

How does the speaker’s description of the fisherman and Icarus illustrate the irony of the situation?

- Ⓐ The speaker creates a comical element to lessen the tension between the characters.
- Ⓑ The speaker contrasts the quiet humility of one character to the rude pride of another.
- Ⓒ The speaker stresses the importance of different characters helping one another through a challenge.
- Ⓓ The speaker praises a character making a living from the sea while criticizing a character struggling against it.

Answer Key: B

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 44%

Reporting Category: Reading Prose and Poetry

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.1.3

Benchmark Description: Analyze the influence of narrator perspective on a text, explaining how the author creates irony or satire.

29. How does Passage 3 adapt the story of Icarus differently than Passage 2 does?

- ☒ (A) In Passage 3, Icarus survives the fall.
- ☐ (B) In Passage 3, Icarus seeks sympathy for his failure.
- ☐ (C) In Passage 3, Icarus regrets not listening to his father.
- ☐ (D) In Passage 3, Icarus acknowledges that he has acted irresponsibly.

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 49%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.3.3

Benchmark Description: Compare and contrast the ways in which authors have adapted mythical, classical, or religious texts.

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- 30.** Complete the table to show how Passage 2 and Passage 3 adapt the story of Icarus.

	Passage 2	Passage 3	Both Passages
mocks Icarus’s foolishness	(A)	(B)	(C)
admires Icarus and his bold adventure	(D)	(E)	(F)
conveys a message by interpreting Icarus’s action	(G)	(H)	(I)

Answer Key: B, D, I

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 36%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.3.3

Benchmark Description: Compare and contrast the ways in which authors have adapted mythical, classical, or religious texts.

The Face of Science

by Sam Kean

- 1 It took six minutes, fifty-one seconds for Albert Einstein to become world famous. That's how long the moon stood suspended before the face of the sun on May 29, 1919, eclipsing its light. Mind you, the astronomers below couldn't sail back home and develop their photographs for weeks; they then needed months more to analyze the results. Within those few minutes that spring day, the scientists had captured the first hard proof of Einstein's theory of general relativity—and with that, launched Einstein himself from the darkness of obscurity into the brightness, even glare, of celebrity.
- 2 Success did not come easy to Einstein. He received no job offers upon graduating from college in 1900, and . . . it took four more years to find work as a physicist.
- 3 Professional struggles aside, Einstein's scientific work dissatisfied him as well. His 1905 paper on special relativity had unified two previously incompatible fields, Galileo's laws of motion and Maxwell's laws of electricity and magnetism. But Newton's theory of gravity had resisted integration, and after 1905 Einstein labored for another decade to bring gravity into the fold. Even then, despite how nifty general relativity looked on paper, Einstein's critics complained that there was no proof that it corresponded to reality.
- 4 So, rather audaciously, Einstein proposed a way for scientists to disprove his theory—if they could. Relativity predicted that gravity should bend light. As a result, light from distant stars should curve as it passed by the sun. This, in turn, made the stars' positions in the sky appear shifted compared with their true positions. The sun's brightness made this shift impossible to observe, of course—except during an eclipse, when stars could peek out from behind its shadow. Search for this shift, Einstein declared, and see if I'm right.
- 5 English astronomer Arthur Eddington took Einstein up on this challenge in May 1919, setting up telescopes and cameras on Príncipe, an island off western Africa famed for its cocoa Rain almost scotched the expedition anyway; only an hour before the eclipse did rain clouds lift over Príncipe. And although Eddington scrambled to take sixteen pictures in those six minutes, fifty-one seconds, only two provided useful data.
- 6 Nevertheless, they revealed enough: The stars had shifted. When Eddington finally had these results in hand, he called it the greatest

moment of his life. And he wasn't alone in gushing. Newspapers worldwide jumped on the story: "LIGHT ALL ASKEW IN THE HEAVENS," read one headline, "MEN OF SCIENCE MORE OR LESS AGOG." Even those who couldn't grasp relativity's nuances knew that this Einstein fellow had transformed our understanding of space and time.

7 From that moment on, we have lived in Einstein's universe—in more ways than one. Beyond confirming a revolutionary theory, the eclipse inaugurated Einstein as a celebrity, making him the face of science worldwide. . . .

8 The hunger for Einstein seems unbelievable in retrospect. Among scientists, a veritable public relations machine of physicists worked to promote general relativity from 1915 onward; six hundred articles and books on it appeared within six years of its debut. The public's hunger proved greater still. A book-length biography of Einstein had appeared by 1921, and he attracted crowds wherever he went, once drawing 15,000 people to Madison Square Garden to celebrate Hanukkah. Churches displayed statues of him, he attended the Rose Bowl parade, and, when he visited Washington, D.C., the U.S. Senate put aside its normal partisan bickering to bicker about relativity theory instead. Einstein appeared on the cover of *Time* on five occasions, and his second wife, Elsa, also got a cover story in *Time*

9 Most admirers cheerfully admitted they didn't understand relativity in the slightest. Marcel Proust¹ adored Einstein for upending our notions about how time flows and how we experience time; pity, then, that Proust couldn't make heads or tails of Einstein's algebra. Even many scientists shrugged. After crossing the Atlantic with Einstein in 1921, Chaim Weizmann, a chemist and later the first president of Israel, commented, "Einstein explained his theory to me every day, and by the time we arrived I was fully convinced that he really understands it."

10 Einstein found the attention thrust upon him flattering, puzzling, and tiresome all at once. "He loved publicity and loved to complain about it," biographer Walter Isaacson noted in *Einstein: His Life and Universe*. But he always tolerated it, for reasons both noble and grubby. . . .

11 Still, Einstein's glamour never faded in the public's eye. He continued to draw crowds wherever he traveled, and whenever he published a new theory, newspaper reporters outdid themselves

¹ Marcel Proust: an influential French novelist

to laud it. In 1929, a London department store even plastered one of his dense, equation-riddled papers in its front window so that crowds could gather around and confirm that, nope, they still didn't understand. That Einstein often ignored these papers later—citing some mistake or misinterpretation and moving on—didn't matter. Reporters fell for it every time and would celebrate the next "breakthrough" with undimmed enthusiasm.

12 Not everyone celebrated Einstein's fame. Colleagues recoiled for the rather quaint reason that publicizing science seemed uncouth. In science, they declared, only ideas matter. . . .

13 A few other scientists in history have achieved celebrity status. Newton and Darwin were buried in London's Westminster Abbey. . . . But no one compares with Albert Einstein. His work strums the deepest chords of our imagination—the nature of time, the origin of the heavens, the ultimate fate of the universe. And he rose to prominence just as new forms of communication made true celebrity status possible. "He came at the moment when almost all the modern media were in place," says Kormos Buchwald. "Newspapers, magazines, photographs, radio. So he was a quintessentially modern scientist in everything, including media exposure."

Excerpt from "The Face of Science" by Sam Kean, from *Humanities Magazine*, May/June 2014, Volume 35, Number 3. In the public domain.

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31. This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

Part A

What is a central idea in the passage?

- Ⓐ Einstein's discoveries helped him achieve success early in his career.
- Ⓑ Physicists felt their work was largely ignored by the media and public.
- Ⓒ Einstein's celebrity status made him a unique figure in the scientific field.
- Ⓓ Newspapers featured Einstein alongside famous politicians and celebrities.

Part B

Which detail supports the response in Part A?

- Ⓐ "His 1905 paper on special relativity had unified two previously incompatible fields, Galileo's laws of motion and Maxwell's laws of electricity and magnetism." (paragraph 3)
- Ⓑ "And although Eddington scrambled to take sixteen pictures in those six minutes, fifty-one seconds, only two provided useful data." (paragraph 5)
- Ⓒ "Most admirers cheerfully admitted they didn't understand relativity in the slightest." (paragraph 9)
- Ⓓ "He continued to draw crowds wherever he traveled, and whenever he published a new theory, newspaper reporters outdid themselves to laud it." (paragraph 11)

Answer Key: C and D

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 40%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.2.2

Benchmark Description: Evaluate the support an author uses to develop the central idea(s) throughout a text.

32. How do the title of the passage and paragraph 7 reflect the author's overall purpose?

- ☒ Ⓐ by emphasizing how Einstein came to symbolize scientific discovery
- ☐ Ⓑ by summarizing how different scientists reacted to Einstein's theories
- ☐ Ⓒ by sharing how popular magazines published about Einstein in the past
- ☐ Ⓓ by pointing out how different Einstein was from the public's perception of him

Answer Key: A

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 76%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.2.1

Benchmark Description: Analyze how multiple text structures and/or features convey a purpose and/or meaning in texts.

Grade 9 FAST ELA Reading Test Release Support Document

- 33.** Select **two** ways paragraphs 5 and 6 develop ideas about Einstein in the passage.
- Ⓐ They indicate how global leaders took notice of Einstein’s previous theories.
 - Ⓑ They demonstrate how other scientists verified Einstein’s theory of relativity.
 - Ⓒ They highlight how a single experiment changed the course of Einstein’s career.
 - Ⓓ They show how Einstein’s scientific ideas created more questions than answers.
 - Ⓔ They describe how science has changed since the time when Einstein began his career.

Answer Key: B, C

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 34%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.2.1

Benchmark Description: Analyze how multiple text structures and/or features convey a purpose and/or meaning in texts.

34. This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

Part A

What central idea about the media does the author develop in the passage?

- ☒ Ⓐ Media's expanding influence helped create Einstein's fame.
- ☐ Ⓑ Media journalists ignored criticism in order to write about Einstein.
- ☐ Ⓒ Media's positive reputation encouraged readers to buy Einstein's papers.
- ☐ Ⓓ Media organizations limited coverage of science due to other popular world events.

Part B

How does the author develop the central idea in Part A?

- ☐ Ⓐ by implying that publications were reluctant to hold Einstein accountable
- ☐ Ⓑ by naming international publications that featured Einstein on their covers
- ☒ Ⓒ by describing the different forms of media that covered Einstein and his work
- ☐ Ⓓ by summarizing how Einstein felt about the attention he received from the media

Answer Key: A and C

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 41%

Reporting Category: Reading Informational Text

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.2.2

Benchmark Description: Evaluate the support an author uses to develop the central idea(s) throughout a text.

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35. Why does the author point out the irony in Einstein’s perspective in paragraph 10?

- Ⓐ to explain why other scientists at the time resented Einstein’s success
- Ⓑ to describe why Einstein became reluctant to continue working in the public eye
- Ⓒ to show that Einstein had less interest in his celebrity status than the public did
- Ⓓ to demonstrate that Einstein came up with theories based on whether they would be accepted

Answer Key: C

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 56%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.3.4

Benchmark Description: Explain an author’s use of rhetoric in a text.

36. This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

Part A

Why does the author suggest that novelist Marcel Proust “couldn’t make heads or tails of Einstein’s algebra” (paragraph 9)?

- Ⓐ to point out how two academic figures in the past had a friendly relationship
- Ⓑ to show how people used to share mathematical discoveries with one another
- Ⓒ to highlight how Einstein struggled to have his ideas proved by other scientists
- Ⓓ to comment on how people admired Einstein’s work without really understanding it

Part B

How does the response in Part A connect to the role of the media in the passage?

- Ⓐ It supports how authors resisted publishing Einstein’s papers.
- Ⓑ It describes how individuals celebrated Einstein’s scientific breakthroughs.
- Ⓒ It shows how other scientists tried to compete with Einstein’s level of publicity.
- Ⓓ It demonstrates how others tried to use Einstein’s popularity for their own benefit.

Answer Key: D and B

Percentage of Students Answering Correctly: 37%

Reporting Category: Reading Across Genres & Vocabulary

Benchmark: ELA.9.R.3.4

Benchmark Description: Explain an author’s use of rhetoric in a text.